

Young adults, alcohol and Facebook: a synergistic relationship

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Abstract

Purpose – There is a growing body of research into the utilisation of social networking sites (SNS) by alcohol marketers, but less research into how young people utilise SNS to create their own meanings of, and interactions with, alcohol. The purpose of this study was to explore young adults' perceptions of the nexus between alcohol and SNS.

Design/methodology/approach – In total, 60 adults aged 18-21 years took part in an intensive data collection process over six months. All references to social media in the interviews, focus groups and written introspections were compiled and analysed.

Findings – Results showed social media use stimulates alcohol consumption and alcohol consumption stimulates social media use. Four main themes emerged: social engagement, identity, drinking culture and distancing. Participants reported being constantly exposed to, and often influenced by, images of their peers enjoying themselves while consuming alcohol, with little representation of negative outcomes.

Research limitations/implications – The relationship between SNS, social norms and drinking behaviours is complex; there is a need for further research into the dynamics of this relationship to inform social marketing interventions.

Originality/value – While there is a body of research into commercial references to alcohol on SNS, there is less research into the ways young people utilise SNS to create their own meanings of, and interactions with, alcohol. The consumer research that has been conducted to date has focused on quantifying references to alcohol and drinking behaviours, observing profiles or surveying users. This study addresses a key gap in the literature that is needed to inform social marketing interventions to reduce excessive alcohol consumption: when, why and how do young people post about alcohol.

Keywords Culture, Social media, Alcohol, Social norms, Facebook, Social identity

Paper type Research paper



Since its origin in 2004 as a networking portal for students, within a decade, Facebook had grown to 1.23 billion monthly users worldwide, 945 million of whom were using their mobile device to access the site (Facebook, 2014). In 2014, the Pew Research Centre reported that while the rate of new users joining Facebook was plateauing, their level of engagement (defined as logging on and actively using Facebook functions) was increasing – with 70 per cent of American internet users aged 18 years and over using Facebook daily (up from 63 per cent in 2013), including 45 per cent logging on several times a day (Duggan *et al.*, 2014). Facebook had 12 million users in Australia in 2014, 9 million of whom were using the site daily and 7.3 million were doing so via their mobile device (Ross, 2014).

There is a growing body of research into the utilisation of social networking sites (SNS) by alcohol marketers, which consistently demonstrates extensive and highly sophisticated marketing activity in this environment, such as Facebook pages created by and/or dedicated to alcohol brands containing ads, events and alcohol brand-related smartphone applications (Griffiths and Casswell, 2010; Mart *et al.*, 2009). Research into the regulation of alcohol marketing on social networking platforms consistently finds such regulation is inadequate and ineffective (Hastings and Sheron, 2013; Hastings *et al.*, 2010), not least because the interactive nature of these platforms – where young people interact with brands to co-create and amplify messages (Brodmerkel and Carah, 2013) – makes it increasingly difficult to attribute ownership of (and responsibility for) message content[1]. Thus, it is not surprising that SNS are becoming an attractive platform for alcohol marketers, particularly in more restrictive regulatory environments (Uzunoglu and Öksüz, 2014).

SNS, alcohol and young people

While there is a body of research into commercial references to alcohol on SNS, there is less research into the ways young people utilise SNS to create their own meanings of, and interactions with, alcohol. Much of the research to date has focused on quantifying the extent to which young people make (positive) references to alcohol and drinking behaviours in their SNS profiles, either by observing profiles or by surveying users (Moreno *et al.*, 2009; Beullens and Schepers, 2013).

For example, in a US survey of 314 undergraduate students (mean age 19.9 years), 32 per cent reported posting pictures of themselves drinking alcohol (Morgan *et al.*, 2010); in an Australian survey of 129 Australian female university students (mean age 21.5 years), respondents reported that, on average, 16 per cent of text posts and 21 per cent of their photo posts were alcohol-related (Miller *et al.*, 2014). Importantly, such studies have found that posting of alcohol-related photos was a significant predictor of alcohol consumption (Miller *et al.*, 2014).

Several studies have combined analysis of SNS profiles with survey data to explore associations between SNS postings and drinking behaviours. Consistent with the findings of the surveys reported above, a study conducted at two US universities found those who displayed references to intoxication or problem drinking in their public profiles had higher alcohol use disorders identification test (AUDIT) scores and were more likely to report having experienced an alcohol-related injury (Moreno *et al.*, 2012). Similarly, an Australian study with 158 university students found an association between the extent of their online “alcohol identity” and measures of alcohol consumption and problematic alcohol-related behaviours (Ridout *et al.*, 2012).

Understanding the social context of drinking (and “sharing” drinking identities) is central to developing successful social marketing interventions to reduce harmful drinking. For example, research with adolescents has shown that being a drinker and having positive attitudes towards drinking are associated with popularity and influence in the peer group (Demant and Järvinen, 2006), and research with young adults suggests that, contrary to the rational approach of government education campaigns, the “fun” associated with excessive drinking is central to the cohesiveness and intimacy of young people’s social friendship groups (Griffin *et al.*, 2009).

Exploratory studies have found that young people use SNS to plan, document and share memories of their night out (Griffiths and Casswell, 2010; Brown and Gregg, 2012; Egan and Moreno, 2011). The abundance of alcohol-related material on SNS, both marketer and user posts, serves to strengthen the perceived normative nature of excessive consumption (McCreanor *et al.*, 2013). Conversely, however, there is evidence that SNS can be used to create supportive social environments to assist young people in reducing their alcohol consumption (Fry, 2014).

More recently, there have been calls for studies to go beyond researcher-directed observations and interpretations of SNS postings and instead explore “what young adults’ uses of SNS in their drinking practices may mean for their understandings – and the dynamics – of their drinking” (p. 879) (Niland *et al.*, 2014). Such information may provide greater insight into young people’s motivations for posting about alcohol products and drinking behaviours, and assist in enhancing the effectiveness of interventions or policies seeking to address current high levels of alcohol-related harm among young people. The current study seeks to address this gap to explore the ways that young adults think about and talk about the nexus between SNS and alcohol.

Methods

This paper reports on data collected as part of a larger study examining 18- to 21-year-old Australians’ alcohol-related beliefs and behaviours. The larger study included focus groups, interviews and written introspections on a range of alcohol-related topics over a six-month period. Social media, the focus of this paper, was a commonly mentioned aspect of alcohol consumption, both in response to direct questioning and incidentally in their discussions; this study did not limit recruitment to participants who were users of Facebook, as recommended in the findings of a recent study (Rains and Brunner, 2016).

Recruitment

The participants in this study were recruited by a social research agency from their database of young adults aged 18-21 years and via advertising on websites and social media platforms (predominantly Facebook). The advertisement read “We are currently recruiting for a long term multiple stage research study in relation to alcohol consumption. This involves participating in discussions about a variety of topics over a period of 6 months [...]” and provided details of the commitment required. Inclusion criteria included being a current drinker (two or more drinking episodes per month), and residing in Perth, Western Australia. To increase representativeness of the sample, the agency was asked to ensure an even number of males and females and younger (18-19 years) and older (20-21 years) participants.

Of the 380 people who responded, 28 per cent (106) were ineligible (primarily due to responding after the relevant age or gender criterion was filled), 52 per cent (197) were unwilling or unable to commit to all of the study components, and 4 per cent (17) decided not to participate after responding to the initial invitation. The 60 final participants were current drinkers (inclusion criterion), with 67 per cent (40) meeting the Australian National Health and Medical Research Council (2009) classification of at risk for harm from their drinking.

This was achieved by asking potential participants how many days per week they consume alcohol and how much they consume on an average drinking day; the “at-risk” cut-off was 14 drinks per week, which was, therefore, inclusive of long-term risk (average of more than two standard drinks per day) and less frequent but heavier drinking (e.g. two drinking sessions per week of eight drinks per session). This group was classified as risky drinkers (RD), and the remaining 33 per cent classified as low-risk drinkers (LRD). According to the most recent national data, of drinkers aged 18-24 years, 62 per cent are LRD and 21 per cent RD in terms of lifetime risk, but 63 per cent drank at risky levels for single occasion risk at least monthly in the last 12 months (Australian Institute of Health and Welfare, 2014). In our sample, 73 per cent ($n = 44$) reported drinking at risky levels for single occasion risk (more than four drinks) at least monthly, slightly higher than the 63 per cent reported in the national data.

Data collection and analysis

Participants took part in an intensive data collection process, known as the sensitisation method (Pettigrew *et al.*, 2015; Pettigrew and Pescud, 2013) over a six-month period in 2014. The sensitisation method combines a range of data collection methods over an extended period, such as self-introspection, memory work, observation, individual interviews and focus groups. Recognising that multiple forms of data allow for triangulation to generate a more robust interpretation than individual data collection methods (Mays and Pope, 2000), the sensitisation method has been used in obesity research to develop a fuller understanding of the multiple complex factors that influence behavior (Pettigrew and Pescud, 2013).

During the six months of the study, the study participants were invited to participate in two individual interviews, one focus group, and 12 introspections (a total of up to 15 data inputs)[2]. The interviews were conducted at the commencement and mid-point of the study, using a semi-structured interview guide; the focus groups were conducted at the end of the study. The introspections (written reflections) enabled the participants to consider and discuss any alcohol-related topic of their choice. Participants who completed all 15 tasks received AU\$600 (an average of AU\$40 per data collection episode). Of the 60 participants, 30 completed all 15 tasks, and a further 19 completed 12 or more.

All interviews and focus groups were recorded and transcribed; the transcriptions and written introspections were imported into NVivo10 (QSR International) for coding and analysis. All references to social media were combined in a sub-file (parent node – social media) and subsequently coded by one of the authors (NB) into “child nodes”[3] relating specifically to engagement with SNS.

Two independent researchers (SJ and JT) then reviewed the codes and conducted a thematic analysis (Braun and Clarke, 2006) on participant interviews, focus groups and introspections for emerging themes related to SNS engagement. The analysis was informed by a social constructionist framework, in which the participants’ sense making of their experiences and realities surrounding alcohol and SNS were examined with a particular focus on how these were socially constructed or reconstructed through language (Crotty, 1998). The themes were identified on an interpretative level where the embedded ideas (or ideologies), beliefs and conceptual framing of the participants’ experiences were explored. After becoming familiar with the data, the two independent researchers searched for themes using initial codes (interesting features within the data). These themes were reviewed and refined in an iterative process; some themes were collapsed into one or two key themes. Broader themes and subthemes were given names to increase thematic internal coherence and consistency (Braun and Clarke, 2006).

Results

While this sub-study of social media references was designed to explore the ways that young adults think about and talk about the nexus between SNS and alcohol, it is important to note that the participants almost exclusively talked about their use of Facebook, owing to this platform's overwhelming popularity. Very few (and generally tangential) references were made to other social media.

Social media, alcohol and the self

Children's social media participation has been described as being characterised by personalisation (creating online identities), hypersociality (constant ability and expectation to be "available"), networking (across platforms, times and places) and ubiquity (Poyntz and Hoechsmann, 2011). We found similar characteristics among the young adults in the present study in terms of their engagement with social media as an aspect of their alcohol consumption.

Social media usage was a frequent topic in the interviews and introspections, with both confirming social media usage as a central aspect of most of these young adults' lives. Consistent with other literature (Hebden *et al.*, 2015; Moewaka Barnes *et al.*, 2016), this was a bi-directional relationship, with social media use stimulating alcohol consumption and alcohol consumption stimulating social media use. Four main themes emerged from the data, each with several subthemes: social engagement, identity, drinking culture and distancing.

Theme 1: social engagement

It was clear from the participants' interviews, focus groups and introspections that the nexus between alcohol and social media was seen as an important facilitator of social engagement. The two were used in combination to establish, enhance and document the interactions between groups of friends:

Alcohol is no stranger to my Facebook newsfeed or Instagram dash. Partly just due to the age group of my friends. Whether it's drunk posts/selfies of my lovely friends just letting loose and being stupid or pictures of their drink of choice with a caption about kicking back or starting the night with a bang. (P43, F, 19, RD, Intro 10)[4]

While each was a part of their connection with peers, the synergistic effect of the substance (alcohol) and the platform (social media) maximised their ability to be, and be seen, as part of the social network. Alcohol references were described as common in all forms of social media, and social media was described as an important component of planning, enjoying and recalling a night out.

Consistent with this, the sub-themes identified within the "social engagement" theme were: planning the night out, enjoying the night out, recalling the night out and demonstrating belonging.

Planning the night out. Participants described using their Facebook profile to connect with friends in planning their night out drinking; planning events, posting their own plans and logging on to read of others' plans. They also used social media to ascertain where people were drinking and to decide which parties to attend based on looking at their friends' posts live from the events:

They might put up a Facebook event inviting people to their house so they're pretty much, yes people might not have binge drunk on that night if that event hadn't have been started but then in a given situation there is pressure on people. (P26, M, 19, RD, Int 2)

Facebook can be hilarious on a Saturday night, I usually start drinking a bit later on Saturdays as I have work until about 9, so before I start drinking going out I check out Facebook, and you can

usually gauge where the good parties are, like if a festival is on or something you can usually tell just by Facebook. (P32, M, 20, RD, Intro 10)

This use of Facebook to decide when and where to drink was not limited to those who were actively seeking social activities to engage in or opportunities to consume alcohol. Participants described Facebook posts as being the catalyst to join friends for the purpose of drinking, even describing occasions where this exposure motivated them to change their plans for a night at home and go out drinking instead:

Heaps of times, when people will post free drinks and you message them something like, oh, you guys, what are you guys up to? They'll be like, we're going out, come meet us at so-and-so's house. Then you get ready really quickly and you go to their house and you start drinking. (P59, F, 20, RD, Int 2)

I can recall numerous occasions in which I have been at home on a Friday night in bed, planning for a night in when I see pictures on Facebook of people going out and this ends up making me have an overwhelming urge to have an impromptu night out. (P10, M, 18, RD, Intro 12)

Enjoying the night out. Many participants described social media as an integral and essential element of their enjoyment of the night out. Taking photos of themselves drinking, having fun and being with friends was seen as an important part of the entertainment and a concrete indicator of how much fun they were having. Participants also referred to "checking in" to a venue on Facebook and tagging friends who were with them in their night out. These posts also served a reminder to those who were not there what they were missing out on. For some, this also had the effect of making them feel unhappy and excluded, as Facebook provided a channel for communicating what would otherwise be unacceptable – that I am enjoying the night out with these people and you are not included in the fun:

I think it has a huge effect. Like people taking selfies [or] photos in a club, and it's like everyone is all friends together, and it seems like so much fun. If you're the one person at home that's not out with a group of friends, you're like, well then, that's a s**t day for me, a really. Whereas if there wasn't social media, people wouldn't text you like, I'm out with this person, this person, this person, and you're not, unless they were horrible. But social media sort of just does that on a grand scale. You see everybody out on a Saturday night, and if you're at home, it makes you sort of - it makes you want to hang out with them, obviously, but when they all hang out in a group like that, it's in a club environment and it's when they're drinking. (P59, F, 20, RD, Int 2)

Participants referred to taking and posting pictures of themselves and their friends drinking, with photos of intoxicated friends seen as the logical progression and, for many, the "fun" element of the interaction between alcohol and social media. Young women, particularly, drew a distinction between "serious" drunkenness, which would require assistance, and "not serious" drunkenness which was fodder for social media, although it was concerning that passing out and vomiting both fell into the latter category.

S (interviewer): So tell me about what you do when your friends or mates are a bit messy and you wanna.

J: Hilarious selfies. That's it. They're vomiting in the bush, you're there going "yeah man this is awesome!" Because they're having a good night.

S: And what do you do with the photos.

J: Social media [...]. You've gotta post that, quick.

K: Yeah, if my friends are drunk I get a lot of Snapchats. Like a lot a lot a lot of Snapchats. But I have like a couple of friends, and they're more like the Josie[5] of the group, and they'll post it on Facebook. Like a few of my friends went to Bali, and one of them got just absolutely drunk. And she was just on the floor, crawling from like her room to the toilet, and my friend videotaped like, videoed the whole thing, and put it on Facebook and tagged her in it. It was, I mean it was funny, it was good-hearted, but, still [...].

J: I never find any issues with my group of friends. For us, it's like you're out to get each other in a kind-hearted way, sorta like "ha, you were the idiot drunk at that party" and then the next weekend or the next time we drink, you'll try and get someone else or get them back, sorta like, pranking each other, yeah. But if they're like really really ill, like quite violently ill, like really sick, you don't do it then obviously. Then we step in and take care of them [...]. But if it's sort of at the beginning, where you know, they've just vomited once or you know, they've, I dunno, they've passed out and you've drawn texta on them, just like light-hearted stuff like that. It's nothing serious. (P19, F, 21, LRD and P11, F, 19, RD; FG)

Remembering the night out. Reviewing their friends' social media posts the following day was perceived as a way of recalling and celebrating the night's events; demonstrating how much fun they had had; having friends' observe and comment on their great night out; and, for some, filling in gaps in memories of their own activities:

Sunday morning is usually spent looking through your tags to decide where you had actually been and what else everyone else has been up to. More often than not, there's a laugh to be had at someone else's drunken expense. Sometimes the expense is of your own, looking at your inability to type, your poor choice of person to communicate with and the array of memory restoring pieces of information. (P27, F, 21, RD, Intro 9)

Demonstrating belonging. Key to this use of social media to tell peers what they were planning, what they were doing, and what they did was the importance of developing and communicating a sense of belonging to a group. Participants frequently mentioned that posting pictures of themselves drinking with others on social media was a concrete demonstration that they have friends. Similarly, having others comment on (or like) their posts was a further reassurance of social connectedness:

If I'm drinking I'm usually out of the house and being social and that's the point of social media is to share and make friends jealous of your experiences. So it's a great motivator to get out there and do things and build your profile and build your experiences and this is heavily symbolised through drinking and drinking leads to meeting new people and so your social profile builds and then you have a better social level. (P 31, M, 18, RD, Intro 7)

If you really want to be seen ladsy on these social media platforms, you would post yourself partying, having premium beer, sculling cask wine and drinking a whole bottle of vodka. This proves to your mates that you are extremely ladsy and belong – have a lot of friends. (P37, M, 21, RD, Intro 12)

Theme 2: identity

The second most common theme was identity; alcohol was seen by many of the participants as a part of their social identity and social media as a key tool for creating and communicating that identity. Sub-themes identified within the theme of "identity" were showing that they're cool, showing that they're having fun, and the power of creation.

Showing that they're cool. The word that was on everyone's lips was "cool". It was clear that these young adults perceive drinking alcohol as an indicator of their status as one of the cool people, and social media as a way of communicating this status to their peers. Alcohol consumption was seen as an integral part of being a "cool person" – and Facebook as a tool for conveying that image to others and gaining social acceptance as part of the in-crowd. This was accompanied by the view that admitting on social media to doing, and enjoying, tamer activities would reduce a person's cool status and was thus to be avoided:

I feel like the intention of how I and everyone else is portraying alcohol is a positive one. It's a social acceptance thing. We want people to know we are doing "cool things" at "cool places" with "cool people". (P54, F, 19, RD, Intro 11)

Because you're just cool. I think. It's like you ask someone how was your weekend and they say it was really good. I bought a new book and then I read, and then I saw that really cool TV show about decorating kennels for dogs. Then you go to the other friend, how was your weekend? Yeah it was pretty good, I got drunk, and I got arrested for peeing outside of a shop at 3:00am on a Friday night. You think well they're a bit cooler. They're the kind of person that I want to become closer with so I can go out and have these fun stories. I don't know, an alcohol night makes a good story. It makes it seem like you're kind of living your life and I guess that's a big thing nowadays with YOLO and shit. It's like the cool people are going out and doing whatever they want so you respect that – them enjoying themselves. (P48, M, 18, RD, Int 2)

Showing that they're having fun. As well as communicating "coolness" and "connectedness", posting on social media was seen as a way of showing the world – or, in some cases, specific individuals – that they were having fun. This ranged from a general sense of showing all their friends that they were out having fun and not sitting at home, to encouragement to others to join the fun next time, and "revenge" posts to show previous romantic partners that they were having fun without them. Participants appeared to feel a sense of self-validation or social validation in demonstrating to others that they are having a good time. While some perceived this as "bragging" or showing off, it was seen as an acceptable form of bragging; a "humble brag" that enabled them to show off their exciting lives in a way that was seen as sharing rather than showing off:

Sometimes, and I'm guilty of it, after I broke up with my last boyfriend and I was getting drunk, I wanted to show him that I was having a good time so I just like posted a picture on Facebook, it's basically to show off to everyone else I think. (P7, F, 18, LRD, Int 2)

I think no one wants to post I'm sitting at home doing nothing. They want to post that they actually have a social life, because everyone for the best self-esteem they need to have an ego boost. So telling everyone that you're Facebook friends with that you're out, that you're having fun and you're not sitting at home doing nothing makes you feel good, I guess. (P23, F, 19, LRD, Int 2)

The power of creation. A number of participants explicitly commented that social media allows them not only to communicate but also to create an identity. One of the perceived benefits of social media was the ability – unlike real life – to craft the ideal image of oneself by carefully selecting what to post. It was clear that for many respondents a considerable amount of thought went into deciding which images to post, and where necessary editing these images, to craft an ideal self for display to others. This was not always seen as a positive thing, with some respondents talking about this behaviour as something that others do to make themselves feel good:

[...] the whole internet presence is very - like you can choose what to post, what to not post, and through that you craft your own - like an extension of your own identity. But it's not the same as people when they see you in real life because you can select angles that photos are taken from, like

Photoshop and stuff. Like I don't like this pimple that's on my cheek so I'll Photoshop this out before I post this photo. (P44, M, 19, RD, Int 2)

People get a high off others knowing that they're "living their life" even if it may be romanticized or written in a way to make it sound better than it is. People want their friends to think that they have a life, and I guess this kind of behaviour does just that in their eyes (P23, F, 19, LRD, Intro 10).

However, some participants cautioned that the ubiquitous nature of social media, and the ability of others to upload and "tag" photos meant that there was also potential to lose control of one's "image":

So I guess social media would be photos and stuff of you drinking, which obviously can either make a positive impact, because it could help build a picture or a persona of what - who you want to show, or it could be a negative because you could look really bad in that photo. So it's definitely a big impact because everyone's always like oh my God the photos from Saturday night went up. I'm like okay, all right. Now I've got to find them. So it's definitely a big deal, social media. (P54, F, 19, RD, Int 2)

Theme 3: drinking culture

Participants commented on the role of social media in normalising drinking and perpetuating the existing culture of excessive consumption among young people. Some also commented specifically on the role of alcohol in the "Australian" culture, with alcohol consumption seen as a normative and necessary element of their image as young Australians:

Being Australian, definitely alcohol is "more of a thing" than in other countries. I have lots of friends from other countries [...]. while drinking is a universal cultural phenomenon, Australians feel socially and culturally obligated to promote images of alcohol. It's part of our national stereotype, that Australians drink lots of alcohol at pubs, and many of our national cultural images include 4XXX cans, goon bags[6], VB, etc. (P7, F, 18, LRD, Int 2)

Sub-themes identified within the theme of "drinking culture" were encouraging drinking, making the culture visible, and projecting a positive spin.

Encouraging drinking. There was a divergence of opinions as to whether the portrayal of alcohol on social media encourages drinking. Some participants stated that exposure to these images definitely encouraged, or even persuaded, them to drink; likening these images to an advertisement for drinking alcohol. These comments focused on the inherent messages in the posted images that the drinkers were happy and having fun, and that drinking could bring about the same positive outcomes for themselves.

However, as with some of the other sub-themes, some participants reported that they were not influenced by exposure to these images, but "other people" might be. Some participants, particularly those who felt that they were not influenced by alcohol use on social media, felt that much of what is posted goes beyond normalising and encouraging drinking to actually glorifying (excessive) drinking:

Reading others posts about alcohol definitely persuades me to drink when I probably wouldn't be tempted otherwise. Furthermore, viewing pictures on social media of friends drinking also gets me in the mood to drink as everyone always look really happy and having a great time! Almost as if it's an actual advertisement for drinking! (P45, F, 21, RD, Intro 10)

[...] like, you see other people having fun on alcohol and it makes you think, mm, I could probably have some fun on alcohol as well, go get drunk. (P50, M, 21, RD, Int 2)

In general, alcohol gets glorified a lot in social media. I'm not a huge user of social media [...] However it doesn't take much more than a quick glance over the news feed on a Friday/Saturday night, or the following mornings to see what effect alcohol has had on people's weekends. (P42, M, 21, RD, Intro 10)

Making the culture visible. A small number of participants expressed the opinion that the primary role of social media in this context is to make (excessive) drinking more visible. They did not believe that their generation has more problematic drinking behaviours than previous generations, rather their drinking is more visible because of the ubiquity and reach of social media:

I don't think however, that it is that unique to our generation. I don't consider our generation to have much worse drinking problems than previous ones, I think it's just more visible and easy to create a moral panic about (P30, M, 20, RD, Intro 10).

Projecting a positive spin. Participants commented on the imbalanced presentation of alcohol on social media. It was clear that as social media profiles are used to convey a positive identity for the individual, alcohol is presented in a positive light. Alcohol consumption is portrayed as a beneficial and almost risk-free behavior; excessive alcohol consumption is even presented as enjoyable, heroic and largely without negative consequences. Physically damaging outcomes are generally presented with bravado, and psychologically damaging outcomes are not revealed. The few negative outcomes that were noted tended to be mild and themselves evidence of the "success" of the night's drinking – such as hangovers or mildly embarrassing but humorous photos. One participant, however, noted that part of this imbalance may be fear of being perceived as a "wowser" if they posted negative comments about drinking or drunkenness:

Some people will act embarrassed by the pictures the next day, usually posting something like "OMG can't believe I did _____ last night". [...] Many people revel in their drunken capers, changing their profile pictures to something stupid and memorable from the night in question, or even just a picture of them passed out on the lawn at 4am with a traffic cone on their head like one of my mates recently. Essentially, alcohol is very rarely portrayed in a negative light on social media. (P47, M, 21, RD, Intro 10)

It's portrayed as a fun thing to do getting drunk or drinking in general and it is all over Facebook. Same as the negative effects of being hungover the day after however the portrayal of the positive fun effects through updates and photos is much stronger than the negative. (P60, F, 21, RD, Intro 10)

A minority of content verges on explicit alcoholism and is quite obviously harmful in nature, but peer pressure will tend to restrain young people in speaking out against it, as will the risk of being perceived to be a "wowser" (someone who hates fun). (P26, M, 19, RD, Intro 12)

Theme 4: distancing

Some of the participants clearly distanced themselves from this perceived culture of over-consumption of alcohol and over-sharing on social media. This included those describing themselves as non-drinkers (despite being a current drinker being an inclusion criterion for the study) and/or non-social media users; and those describing themselves as invulnerable to social media influences. For some, this use of social media to display the extent of their alcohol consumption was seen to be more common among younger, naïve drinkers:

It's not really me so I'm not sure what's going through their mind when they're doing it. Especially with girls, like I don't see any real benefit in posting pictures of your night out when you're laying

half naked on the road or things like that and I'm not sure whether that's just a spur of the moment thing or whether they actually think that's a good thing to do. (P60, F, 21, RD, Intro 2)

I think portraying alcohol in social media is done mainly by the as I like to call them "new wave 18 year olds". They have just started being able to legally buy drinks and they want to show this off in social media so they post a picture. (P58 F, 20, RD, Intro 10)

However, others described engaging in both drinking alcohol and sharing alcohol-related posts, but perceived themselves as more restrained or sophisticated than "those" people who post inappropriate or potentially embarrassing images of themselves while under the influence of alcohol. This group of participants also described their own alcohol-related posts as incidental to the other activities or behaviours they were posting about, but others' alcohol-related posts as focused on the consumption of alcohol *per se*. Those who distanced themselves from (excessive) drinking and sharing commented on the negative image that these behaviours can convey. They were quite disparaging about "those" people, and made a distinction between posting "classy" and "trashy" photographs:

I guess if I go out the same happens with me too, except I don't share the photos to show that I am drinking alcohol, mainly just to show that I am having fun with my friends! (P12, F, 19, LRD, Intro 12)

I think there are two ways people want to be view in social media one is classy and grown up for e.g. selfie with a glass of wine a book and candles and the other is look how much/how wasted I am e.g. empty bottles or passed out/being sick. (P19, F, 21, LRD, Intro 12)

Discussion

This study used a different approach from much of the existing literature – exploring the way social media was discussed in the context of alcohol consumption, rather than the way alcohol consumption was discussed in the context of social media. We found that social media use was frequently, and often spontaneously, discussed when talking about drinking behaviours. This illustrates the extent to which alcohol and social media use have become conjoined in young adults' lives, and suggests efforts to reduce alcohol-related harms in this age group will need to appreciate and accommodate the relationship between these two pastimes.

Social media and alcohol: "being" and "belonging"

Our findings are consistent with, and build on, those from research in New Zealand (Niland *et al.*, 2014) which used a go-along methodology to discuss with seven young people alcohol-related postings on their Facebook pages.

The first theme identified, "friendship group belonging", was consistent with our social engagement theme in that it focused on using Facebook to share social experiences and demonstrate connectedness to the friendship group. This social nature of Facebook was also highlighted in a two-part qualitative Australian study (data collected in 2007 and 2009/2010), which found that a primary motivator for moving from MySpace to Facebook was the differentiation between MySpace as a place for introspective self-narrative and Facebook as a dynamic and social platform with real-time interaction between friends (Robards, 2012). This is also consistent with the findings of a study of Facebook self-disclosure more generally, which found that self-disclosure on Facebook was predicted by the combined motives of exhibitionism and relationship maintenance (Hollenbaugh and Ferris, 2014).

Our theme of "identity" was consistent with the second major theme in the New Zealand study (Niland *et al.*, 2014), "balanced self-display", with participants describing active

selectivity in the posting, tagging and untagging of images. Our “drinking culture” theme was similar to their final theme, “absences in positive photos”, in that it emphasised the portrayal of alcohol consumption on Facebook as a positive experience with strategic avoidance or removal of images and comments about negative effects of drinking.

Social media and alcohol: positive deviance

However, we also found additional themes and nuances in themes that are likely due to the different methodologies. As the New Zealand study utilised a methodology of walking-through participants’ pages, the focus of the discussions was on what was portrayed on the pages (particularly the photographs and images) (Niland *et al.*, 2014). By comparison, our methodology elicited discussion about the way that Facebook is *used* by participants and the impact it has on their behaviour. We also found that a number of our participants distanced themselves from alcohol-related displays on Facebook, describing this as something that “other people” do – which may be due to differences between the two samples, or the ability of our participants to deny (to themselves as much as to the researchers) that they engage in these behaviours as their Facebook profiles were not visible to us.

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Social media and alcohol: creating and communicating social norms

The role of SNS, such as Facebook, in developing and communicating alcohol-related attitudes, beliefs and behaviours is an important ongoing area of study. Social Cognitive Theory (SCT) (Bandura, 1986) states that individuals learn behaviours from observing and imitating others, and that this includes both models in their physical environment (Bandura *et al.*, 1961) and mediated models (Bandura *et al.*, 1963), such as television portrayals. SNS combine both of these in that people are typically observing people they know in both physical and online spaces. Central to SCT are the principles of identification (people are more likely to copy those they perceive to be similar to themselves) and outcome expectancies (people are more likely to copy behaviours they observe to result in positive outcomes), along with self-efficacy. Studies on adolescent alcohol consumption have evidenced these effects for both physical exposure (Samek *et al.*, 2013) and mediated exposure (Wasylikiw and Currie, 2012). Similarly, research into alcohol portrayals in the media – such as television and movies – suggests that “entertainment media” often presents young people with attractive models, who are similar to themselves or to who they aspire to be, experiencing predominantly, but not solely, positive outcomes from alcohol consumption (Callister *et al.*, 2012).

The results of our study suggest that SNS portrayals of alcohol take this one step further. Our study participants reported constant exposure to images of their peers enjoying themselves while consuming alcohol, with emphasis on the highly positive social outcomes and little representation of what members of this age group consider to be negative outcomes. It is, therefore, likely that young people exposed to these messages about alcohol consumption on SNS such as Facebook will “learn” that (excessive) alcohol consumption is normative, desirable and associated with positive outcomes. Participants were consciously aware that the images produced a desire to mimic the behaviour, resulting in larger quantities of alcohol being consumed than would otherwise have occurred.

There is also some evidence from studies in the USA that younger adolescents who are exposed to pro-alcohol messages on SNS profiles (such as those of older siblings or friends) are likely to exhibit more positive attitudes to alcohol consumption and greater susceptibility to drinking (Litt and Stock, 2011), even when they recognise that these portrayals may not represent actual alcohol consumption (Moreno *et al.*, 2009).

Social media and alcohol: whitewashing and window dressing

Our finding that participants reported posting, and viewing, predominantly positive messages about alcohol – and actively avoiding or deleting negative references – is consistent with a US analysis of the Facebook profiles of 160 college students which found that references to alcohol, and peer responses to these, were positively valenced for 72.2 per cent of the posted images and 72.8 per cent of the updates (Beullens and Schepers, 2013). It is important to note that studies into the effects of media portrayals of alcohol consumption have shown that the absence of negative consequences can be as influential as the presence of positive consequences (Bahk, 1997).

An important consideration surprisingly not raised by the participants in our study is the potential long-term impacts of posting alcohol-related messages on Facebook. As Moreno and colleagues noted in their study of the patterns of alcohol references on college students Facebook pages in the USA, these young adults appear to be unaware of (or unconcerned about) the potential for these postings to damage their future educational or employment opportunities. Employers may take a very different view to peers on the appropriateness of the postings and, in countries such as the USA where underage drinking is illegal, there is also a potential for more immediate ramifications from such postings (Moreno *et al.*, 2014).

Limitations

There are a number of limitations of the current study that should be considered. First, our reliance on a self-selected group who responded to an invitation to participate means the findings may not be representative of the broader population of young-adult drinkers. We endeavoured to mitigate this by using multiple recruitment strategies and establishing quotas for age and gender, and including LRD in the sample. As such, our findings may, in fact, be more representative of this group than much of the existing literature, which focuses solely on undergraduate university students. Second, our participants took part in 15 data collection episodes, of various forms, during a six-month period, so will have given greater thought to their attitudes and behaviours surrounding alcohol than many young adults. Third, in interviews and focus groups, participants generally spoke most freely about their friends' (or friendship group's) social media practices rather than their own. Determining gender differences in social media practices from only respondents speaking about the practices of their broader social group can be problematic. Future studies could explore gender differences in the generation of, and response to, alcohol-related SNS posts.

Conclusion

The relationship between SNS, social norms and drinking behaviours is complex. While many studies have shown a high prevalence of alcohol-related postings on young people's SNS profiles, there have been inconsistent findings in relation to the effects of others' postings on individuals' drinking behaviour. Our study highlighted the dynamic and synergistic relationship between alcohol consumption and social media postings about drinking, where both of these elements are seen by many young adults as a necessary and valuable part of their socialisation with peers. The ubiquitous and positive nature of messages about alcohol on SNS identified in our study, and previous studies, suggests that there is a need for further research to clarify the dynamics of this relationship. Understanding this relationship is key to develop effective social marketing interventions that resonate with young adults, recognise the complex self-identity and social bonding functions of the nexus between alcohol and social media and provide viable alternative behaviours to fulfil these functions.

Notes

1. The ability of internet marketing to cross international borders further complicates the situation. While traditional forms of advertising can be regulated (and what is acceptable determined) based on the alcohol-related laws within that country, websites are generally accessible from anywhere in the world, making it virtually impossible to restrict access to alcohol marketing to only those legally old enough to purchase and consume alcohol. In the USA, it is illegal to drink alcohol under the age of 21 years; in Australia. It is illegal to purchase alcohol under the age of 18 years, but not illegal to consume it in private premises; in the UK, it is also not illegal for a 16- or 17-year-old to drink alcohol in licensed premises if they are accompanied by an adult.
2. Further details on the data collection tools are available on request from author SP.
3. This is the terminology used by the software: "Nodes are containers for your themes, people, places, organisations or other areas of interest. You can organise these nodes in hierarchies – moving from general topics at the top (the parent node) to more specific topics (child nodes)" (http://help-nv10.qsrinternational.com/desktop/concepts/about_nodes.htm).
4. Quotes are identified by participant number (P), sex (M or F), age, drinking status (RD = risky drinker, LRD = low risk drinker), data collection form and number (e.g., FG = focus group, Int 1 = interview 1, Intro 4 = introspection 4).
5. Pseudonym.
6. [Cheap wine in a plastic bladder within a cask/box].

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